

to quit after the Rio Olympics. Can you elaborate on the reasons and what changed your mind?

It is not that my game was not growing. It was more due to the age factor and personal reasons; the family was also growing. We decided to move back from Germany after the Rio Olympic Games. We had decided two years before that that we would move back to India. We will slowly get back to our usual lives.

But I had this injury in 2015 and started working and putting myself back into training. In 2016, just qualifying for the Olympic Games was a herculean task. I somehow made it and went there, but I lost very early, and the way I lost, it was one of the worst Olympic Games that I ever played in terms of the quality of matches.

When we came back to India, I wanted to look forward to the 2018 Commonwealth

Games since I had worked so much. I spent nearly 19 years in Europe and gained a lot of experience and knowledge. At that point, I focussed a lot more on physical fitness. Ramji Srinivasan put me through a tough fitness routine, as he always does, and I was able to prolong it. 2018 was a watershed year for Indian table tennis, with eight Commonwealth Games medals, including team golds. Then, winning medals (two bronze) at the Asian Games for the first time was phenomenal.

I felt if I could get an Asian Games

medal, let me try for an Olympic medal. Tokyo getting postponed by another year gave me more time to prepare, and the gap between Tokyo and the Birmingham Commonwealth Games became shorter. And once it came, the Hangzhou Asian Games moved. The target just kept moving. But now I feel I can't push it to LA 2028. It's not fair on my family because they are sacrificing a lot for something they are not aspiring to be. It also adds responsibility for me to take care of them, spend more time with them, and be around them. That's also the reason why I keep telling people that

A photograph of Sharath Kamal, a male table tennis player, smiling and holding a large, ornate trophy. He is wearing a dark suit and a blue tie. Behind him, Syed Kirmani, an older man with a mustache, is also smiling and looking at the trophy. He is wearing a blue and white patterned shirt. The background is a plain, light color.

SHARATH KAMAL, THE SPORTSTAR ACES 'SPORTSTAR OF THE YEAR – MALE', FOR THE YEAR 2023, RECEIVES HIS AWARD FROM FORMER INDIA WICKETKEEPER SYED KIRMANI

this is going to be my last Olympic Games.

What is going to be your physical and mental preparation for the Paris Olympics? Have you discussed a plan with your team?

For the next four months, my younger brother Rajath and strength-and-conditioning coach Ramji Srinivasan have made a plan.

The first three weeks in April are going to be very hard. I'm spending almost three hours in the gym and three on the table. We're going to mix that up for three weeks in April. Then, as we slowly get into May, we will spend more time in the hall. So, four to five hours of table tennis,